



to this otherwise boring and plain-boring category of desktops.

The desktop we received was the OptiPlex 960. At first glimpse itself, it looks like it means business even though it was one of the smallest in this test. The case is covered with tiny holes which give it its distinctive look and it also helps with some ventilation. The DVD drive, the audio connectors and the USB connectors form the rest of the face of the OptiPlex. Dell didn't send us a display with the desktop but they did a keyboard and a mouse which were as expected similar to what we've seen on some other desktops before. The mouse is shaped well and the keyboard comes with a detachable palm-rest.

Opening the case is simple. The rear of the case has a slider which unlocks the side panel. Unlike other desktops, the motherboard is mounted on the left panel and the right panel unlocks. At first, everything looks inaccessible and crowded. The view inside is blocked by a large flat surface. One then notices the clips surrounding the various pieces. The main panel is a door which reveals the two 2.5-inch 160GB mounted on it. The drives are arranged in a RAID setup. The optical drive used too is a slim DVD writer to try and save space. This drive can also be released using a similar clip mechanism. Under the DVD drive lies the cooling for the processor. A fan sucks in air from the front of the case to the heatsink behind it and then is channeled out from the back.

The surprises don't end there. The processor on this tiny desktop for the office has an Intel Core 2 Quad Q9550 running at 2.8 GHz. There's also 8 gigabytes of memory in a 4 x 2 GB configuration lined up on the board. This hardware ensures that the competition is demolished. The performance is ridiculous. In processor-intensive benchmarks such as Cinebench, it's around two times faster than its nearest competitor. The RAID hard drives also churn up mindboggling numbers. A 1 GB file only takes 16 seconds to copy. Even though the GMA 950 isn't a great graphics solution on a PC of this kind of power, it still manages to get results with the help of the powerful processor. Office goers using this PC will be able to easily play rounds of Far Cry with an average frame rate of 60 frames per second.

Although all this power is there when you need it, it's not sure what kind of office work demands such hardware. The kind of hardware here is not even seen on many gaming rigs. Still, there's a price one pays for this kind of power. The OptiPlex 960 is priced at Rs 58,000 in the market without the LCD screen. It is expensive but if you want to be seen with a

really good desktop at work, then this is the one for you.

HCL EZEEBEE MAX XP P999

The HCL EZEEBEE MAX XP P999 is a very entry-level PC for the masses that makes use of the latest Atom processors. From the outside, it looks like any other desktop PC. When you open up the big cabinet, you discover a tiny board on it. It is an Intel i945G motherboard with an Intel Atom N230 processor running at 1.6GHz. It's almost the same thing used in netbooks. It only comes with 1 GB of memory.

The insides are spacious but the cables aren't tied up very tidily. The case is simple, looks decent and is built well. The cooling fan for the processor is tiny but good for the low-power Atom processor but the setup is still pretty noisy due to

the full size power supply fan. A scoop is mounted on the side panel to let the tiny CPU fan



HCL EZEEBEE MAX XP P999

pull in cool air from the outsides. There is no room for expansion on this tiny i945 board and it means that you can only put in an additional memory stick and a PCI card.

The entire system seems like a waste of space. A tinier cabinet would have done wonders and would be much more attractive for many users. The keyboard supplied with the HCL is standard, comes with multimedia keys and keys for Internet functions. The layout is a little crowded near the center panel between the numerical pad and the character keys.

In comparison to other desktops we tested, the EZEEBEE MAX XP P999 is bad. It's not exactly cheap at Rs. 19,999. If cheaper and maybe a bit smaller in size, people who want only browsing capabilities or a system for downloading would find it most excellent!

HCL EZEEBEE UP Z811 C2D

The HCL UP Z811 is the more impressive of the two HCL desktops we received. Unlike the MAX XP P999 is built in a chassis that can be placed horizontally or vertically. It is thinner than most other desktops we've seen this test but not as small as the Dell OptiPlex 960 and the Acer Aspire NX4440.

It has a very nice design and



Intels Rs. 5000 comp

Intel has launched a Rs. 5000 desktop for the Indian market with its Atom processor.

look. A single optical drive and the USB panel with audio connectors and finally a card reader take up three-thirds of the front panel. The last bit of area has the classy power buttons and LED indicators. All the panels have a press-and-release lock to them.

The entire case is built well. The top of the case has an opening right about on top of the processor fan from CoolerMaster. The case runs pretty warm. At the heart of this system lies a pretty powerful 2.8GHz Intel Core 2 Duo E7400 and an Intel G31 based motherboard.

The performance of the system is good at the WinRAR compression and Cinebench rendering tests. One of the most impressive components is the 320 GB hard drive which showed transfer rates of 83 MB/s in the SiSoft Sandra benchmarks and also the realworld file transfer tests. The performance of the system in gaming benchmarks was pretty bad.

The chassis of this system

is pretty good and is definitely a bit more spacious than the other compact desktop cases. The 19-inch LCD that came with the HCL desktops is average and have speakers are mounted at the bottom of the screen. The screen along with the desktop makes it look like a very traditional and simple desktop PC. At

Rs. 27,999, it's in the same price

bracket as the Acer Aspire NX4440 but doesn't offer as good a graphics solution.

HP Pavilion A6740

HP's Pavilion range has been around for ages now and the a6700 series is the latest they have for offer. The range is usually targeted at home users and also at basic office use. We received the A6740 and it came in a very fancy avatar. It has the regular mid-tower form factor but is the classiest looking one in this comparison test. The tower has a small glowing power button at the top of the case. Below that is the media card reader which supports all commonly used card formats.

The insides of the Pavilion are secured and there are metal strips in place to stop users from making changes. The motherboard is mounted on the other side and thus the processor ends up at the base of the case. The hard drive is mounted vertically and all the cables are tied to reduce the mess inside. There is space for expansion on the board for a graphic card and also an empty memory slot.

We received an equally stylish 19-inch HP display as well. The display has a nice glossy bezel but the most special thing about is its interface which is extremely detailed yet very simple to use. It's something very few LCDs today have. The keyboard is great and has multimedia buttons lined up along the sides of the keyboard. The mouse feels light and is lower than some other mice.

One of the irritating things is the



Dell OptiPlex 960